Falling Man

By Will Scheffer

You get used to the sound of the wind as it rushes past your ears. And the ominous sense of velocity becomes familiar after a while. You watch as the stars whiz by you like flying candles. You listen to the planets as they sing their songs. You think to yourself, at any moment I am going to come crashing down into the Earth, but you never do. At least not yet.

You begin to wonder about gravity. You become obsessed with it. You say to yourself over and over: I'm falling I'm falling, but soon you get used to not having your feet on the ground anymore. In fact, ground itself, becomes a concept that no longer has any meaning to you.

You convince yourself that if you are talking, if someone can hear you, you must still be alive. You scream: I'm alive I'm alive, to no one in particular. You discover you don't like looking down, but prefer to look up, for obvious reasons. And then quite suddenly, for a moment, without warning: you have this unbearable urge to Cha Cha once more.

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INTRODUCTION

Nearly a quarter of a century has passed since reports of a voracious disease with an ability to destroy immune systems appeared in The New York Times. At the time, neither the disease, nor the agent that caused it, had names. Today they are known only too well: HIV causes AIDS. In the 1980s and 1990s, AIDS cut a devastating swath through the dance world, cutting short too many lives and careers. Falling Man by William Scheffer recounts one dancer's experience as he reflects on the rise and fall of his dancing career and his life. Falling Man by William Scheffer

Before I started falling, I was a ballroom dancing champion, expert at ten dances. On a perfect night in 1983, at the age of 22, I became the Cha Cha champion of the world. No one much remembers that now, but it's true. Even before this however, I was famous for

my Cha Cha. My dancing partner Svetlana defected from the Soviet Union in 1981, specifically to dance the Cha Cha with me. And, at that time, we were legendary. You would have loved Svetlana. She had an accent just like Norma Shearer in Idiots Delight. You know, all "vonderfuls" and "werys" . . . "I am so wery, wery crazy about you," she would often say to me. As I said before, we won the title of Cha Cha champion of the world on a perfect night in January of 1983. And we were perfect that night, as we moved across the dance floor of the Cincinnati Hilton Hotel. The floor was so highly polished that a few couples actually fell that evening. But not us. My strong arms that night; supported Svetlana in poses of inspired and delirious sexuality. Our footwork was impeccable and unrivaled. We glittered and sparkled and shined. Perhaps there could have been more of a natural passion between us, yes, but our acting was flawless and inspired. Not for a second was there a false move to our grace, to our speed and authority. And I now realize that in my life up until that moment there had never ever been even the remotest possibility of falling. It wasn't even a question. I would not have allowed it. I was not that kind of person. No.

That night we floated, we glided, we dazzled. And for a moment at the very climax of our passionate Cha Cha embrace, I was almost happy.

You must forgive me for talking so much. It's just that since I - started - falling - I don't dance anymore. I hope I'm not boring you. Really all I'd like to do is entertain you. You see, that's what ballroom really is about, it's - entertainment and - it makes people feel good about life, about living, about being alive. Yes! That's what I'd really like to do more than anything else. "Oh I'd like to do a Cha Cha but the lesions hurt my feet!" Sorry. Bad joke. Anyway. That night, Svetlana and I celebrated in my hotel room. We drank champagne from her silver slipper, we got drunk, and I convinced her that we should make an appearance at the party in the hotel.

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When we made our entrance the party was in full swing the waves seemed to part for us. Compliments flowed endlessly along with all the alcohol, but I felt uncomfortable that night with Svetlana on my arm. Sometimes it seems to me that Destiny has a way of making you ready for her arrival. Of creating the conditions necessary for her to play out her cards. Because I can't explain why I felt as I did on the night of my triumphant Cha Cha, that my young life until then had been nothing more than a championship performance a perfect ten absolutely, but just a performance none the less. And no sooner than I had this impression, I saw an enchanting stranger from across the room. He was not precisely a stranger, but I had never met him, as Pablo, a Brazilian dancer. You might find this hard to believe, but at the ripe age of 22, even in that day and time, I was still a virgin on that night in Cincinnati, in 1983. And as Pablo came closer my heart beat with a fear, but there was no turning back. Destiny had opened its arms wide to greet me and soon so had Pablo, who kissed me warmly on both cheeks with congratulations. This action on his part caused an uncontrollable "reaction" on my part so to speak.

I don't really know how to put into words what happened next. If I could I would dance it for you; I would dance that night and not trivialize it with words. Sometimes I think love is about inventing, a private language, a language that lovers makeup, that only they can speak and understand - isn't that what love is just an intoxicating language that you have forgotten and must now remember.

I wonder if you can understand what it felt like to me - please try because tonight I want us to be like lovers - but I wonder if you can, can know what it felt like for me to dance the Cha Cha with him. To dance with a man. For me, who had danced a thousand sambas, with a thousand lovely women, in a thousand sparkling rooms, for me to dance with a man for the first time in my life.

How can I explain it to you. How can I describe it as I fell. As I fell for the first time in

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my young life. As we fell into each other. As we danced.

You must forgive me for talking so much. I know it's silly but I am afraid that you will forget me and my Cha Cha. That you will judge me. That you will condemn me for falling that night. I want so much to entertain you, but you must understand, that night, it was as if I had to fall. As if a person like me had just been waiting to fall all his life. And it felt not so much as if I were falling, but more like I was being born, but of course you understand that don't you?

I'm afraid I'm running out of time. I'll just tell you this. Pablo died a year later. It was so fast, not long after that Svetlana took me to the clinic to get tested. And I've been falling ever since.

You know, sometimes I see the other falling people around me and I want to grab onto them as we fall. I want to dance with them up here in the sky. So everyone can look up and just see these fabulous falling people. I think that would be terrific, but it's so hard to organize.

I have to stop talking. I do have one thing to ask you though. When I am finished remember that I used to dance the Cha Cha, that I was the Cha Cha champion of the world. And remember the sound of my voice

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier

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